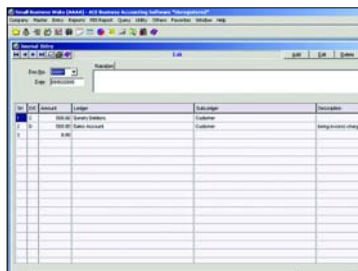


features, and the differences across the software were minimal. This was expected, as they are all accounting software, all made to take care of the well-defined, result-oriented task that is accounting. There really aren't too many different ways to balance your books, now, are there?

ACE 7.0

www.coralindia.com

ACE is a strong contender for the crown, and hits back with a set of decent features. The most noteworthy feature is its excellent support for ASCII dot-matrix printers, so you won't have to invest in a new printer and spend so much more money on paper



ACE 7.0 has support for ASCII dot-matrix printers

sheets and ink—medium-sized companies where thousands of account reports have to be printed every week are sure to appreciate this feature.

ACE 7.0 is totally compatible with Windows, and can Zip and e-mail reports to your clients. It can export or save files in MS Word and Excel, or HTML for those who need to publish reports online. The interface is pretty easy to get used to as well.

The software isn't taxing on the system either; it performs commendably in terms of speeds, even on older, slower computers. It has some great features, such as bank reconciliation, tracking duplicate cheque numbers, managing multiple purchase and sales accounts, calculating commissions based on quantities sold, calculating discounts, product-wise price lists, and much more.

In terms of inventory management, the software offers options such as batch-wise stocking, various inventory evaluations such as LIFO, FIFO, market, average, stock ageing analysis, calculating profit and loss on a per-product basis, and loads more.

Though ACE can create user-defined reports, you might need to be a software engineer or a programmer to be able to do so! It has a native barcode reader for importers and exporters, and has a very useful inbuilt data backup-and-restore function.

Overall, ACE is a very good software product, and it has what it takes to be your businesses accounting solution.

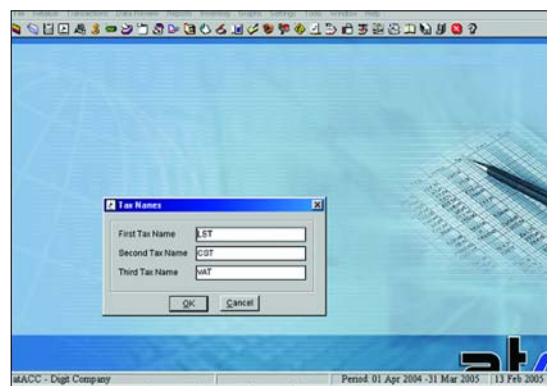
atACC

www.atlanta-it.com

atACC, apart from having a cool pun for a name, is another offshore product that doesn't really come preset for the Indian accounts system. The software is extensive, and has every feature that you would expect accounting software to have. However, there are too many useless fields in a form, and all of them are predefined. So you end up with fields that are displayed but will never be used. In order to disable these fields, you have to set up the account tree with the items, and then edit the master.

Accounts and items can be grouped for convenience, but there is no option for a multi-line inventory. Thus, each pack size would need to be an individual entry.

Once you have created your masters, however, things begin to flow a little better. You can enter transactions related to banks, cash, purchases, sales, and more. The most noticeable advantage of this software, however, is the abil-



atACC doesn't come preset for the Indian accounts system

The most noticeable advantage of atACC is the ability to increase, decrease and transfer stock from one code to another

ity to increase, decrease and transfer stock from one code to another. Using this, you can manipulate your stock better and prevent shortages or excesses of stock across your company. It also has an inbuilt 'Free Quantity' feature, which will help you keep track of all the freebies that you give away with your products. The software religiously keeps reminding you to back up your data every time you exit it.

atACC seems to be really efficient when going all the way down to the voucher level from the reports, but we realised that the values were not being refreshed after saving and closing the report. The software also limits you to three tax types, and there's no way to add a fourth. Also available is the inventory handling option for shortages, excess and damages. atACC also helps define services and keeps a

How We Tested

All the software we tested were targeted at the SoHo segment. Here, ease of use and features are overshadowed by the total cost of ownership factor.

We roped in a couple of external consultants to help us evaluate the software. Both qualified chartered accountants, they set up multiple dummy companies, used dummy data and entered standard trading transactions to figure out how easily and how well the software handles them.

Ease of use is important for any software, but since the focus is on the SoHo community, who may not have a full-time accountant doing their accounts, we gave a very high weightage to how easy the software is to install and use. How easy it is to set up new companies, users and master accounts was given due weightage. Since we are focused here towards the SoHo and small trader community, we focused only on those features of the accounting packages that are relevant for these communities. Therefore, features such as accounting without codes, receivables and payables management, multi-company accounting, invoicing, printing features, etc. were given higher weightages.

ASCII dot-matrix printing is of importance to the SoHo community, so this feature, if available, was awarded points. The reporting features of the packages and their ability to export reports to other formats such as Microsoft Excel and Adobe Acrobat were noted. Other features such as multi-currency accounting, multiple users, and online publishing were not considered very important. Since most of these software also support inventory management, we noted features such as re-order levels, multiple units, batch wise inventories, etc.

Finally, the cost of the software was taken into account to decide the winners.